

THE MAN MADE OF CLAY

A Comparative Journey Through the Myths of Human Creation

Preface

This book grew out of a simple question —one that grew less simple the more it was pursued: why did so many peoples, with no contact between them, all tell the same story: that the first human being was made of clay?

The easy answer is that clay is everywhere — anyone who has watched mud dry along a riverbank or looked at a newly fired vessel straight from the kiln, instantly understands the comparison between that malleable material and a body that begins as nothing at all and ends standing upright. That answer is true, but it is not enough. It does not explain why, over and over, the material chosen to fashion humanity comes accompanied by something more: alien blood mixed into the clay, a different color of earth for each people, a cord flinging mud to separate nobles from commoners, a kiln left too long that decides who is born with what skin color.

In these stories, clay is almost never just clay. It is also a way of telling who rules, who works, who belongs, and who is left outside.

This book gathers some of these stories —from Mesopotamia, Egypt, China, Mesoamerica, North America, Africa, and the Levant— and reads them through two steady questions: what is the human being made of in each story, and what does that choice tell us about the people who told it? Some of the answers offered here are firmly anchored in available evidence; others are open hypotheses, presented as such, and the reader will find throughout the text a careful —at times perhaps overly careful, but deliberate— distinction between a proven fact, a possibility, and an intuition. Where evidence suffices to support an identification, it is stated. Where it does not, the text says "*it could be*" and explains why, recording what was investigated but not demonstrated, rather than remaining silent about it.

The book closes with a chapter unlike the others: it deals not with an external myth, but with the Hebrew creation text itself, read in light of a hypothesis concerning its geographic and historical origin. This final chapter does not claim to close a centuries-long debate — it seeks, like all those before it, to place one possible reading on the table, with both its supports and its limitations clearly in view.

Chapter 1 — The Blood of the One Who Knew How to Listen: Enki, Nintu, and Geshtu-e

The Text

Around the 17th century BCE, somewhere in a scribal school of Old Babylonian, a scribe wrote down a story that had circulated long before: the poem we now call *Atrahasis*. It relates that in the beginning there were no humans — only gods — and the gods had to work. The great gods, the Anunnaki, divided the sky, the earth, and the underworld among themselves, and assigned the hardest labor to the lesser gods, the Igigi: digging the canals that made the plain between the Tigris and Euphrates habitable.

For forty years the Igigi dug. Then one night they burned their tools, surrounded the temple of Enlil, and refused to go on working. It was not a request. It was a strike — with their tools already in flames.

Enlil, terrified, summoned the great gods. And it was Enki —the cunning one, lord of the Abzu, the one who always found a way out— who proposed the solution: if the problem is that someone must do the work, then someone new must be created to bear it. Not another god. A new being, made expressly to carry the basket the Igigi would no longer carry.

The Sacrifice That Is Not a Conquest

Here lies the detail that changes everything one would expect from this story, and worth emphasizing before proceeding: the being sacrificed to make humanity possible is not an enemy captured in war. Not a defeated king, not the leader of a rival army, not someone from "outside." It is one of the Igigi themselves — the very gods who had gone on strike.

His name is Geshtu-e, "he who has an ear " or "*he who has intelligence*" — in some versions he is called simply We-ila, Ilawela, "*the divine man*." And it is precisely his

intelligence that seals his fate: the great gods choose him for sacrifice because he is the wisest of all, the one who possesses *da'at*, understanding. They kill him in their own assembly. The goddess Nintu (also called Mami, Belet-ili, Ninhursag, or Ninmah, depending on tradition) mixes his flesh and blood with clay, and from this mixture she molds fourteen portions — seven on the right, seven on the left — who become the first fourteen human beings.

There is no conquest here. There is an internal agreement: the whole group, knowing it must resolve its labor crisis, decides that one of their own — the most capable — must die so that the rest may rest. It is a foundational sacrifice, but a horizontal one, not vertical. The Igigi do not defeat an enemy; they sacrifice themselves, in the person of their finest member, to invent a working class that is not themselves. This matters because it changes the question we must ask of the myth. The right question is not "what enemy people does Geshtu-e represent?" — because the text does not present him as anyone's enemy. The right question is different: what population, already integrated into the system but subordinated within it, might have inspired this image of "one of us, sacrificed so the rest need not work the land"?

The poem does not answer that question — it does not identify Geshtu-e with any specific historical people, and it is proper to state this clearly before proposing anything. What the myth does offer, without forcing the reading, is the social structure of the sacrifice: not an enemy defeated in war, but a member of the community itself whose death transfers agricultural labor onto a new category of beings. From that observation — firmly anchored in the text itself — one may explore a reading hypothesis, not a proven identification: that the narrative preserves, transformed, the memory of a subordinated population already tied to the land before the Sumerians themselves emerged as such. Read this way, Geshtu-e would not be an individual character but a figure condensing a social experience — the transfer of agricultural labor from a dominant group to another group integrated in subordination — without implying that the poem refers to a people whose name we can now recover.

Comparative Support: The Substratum That Left No Name — But Left Its Words

Is there anything outside the myth itself that lends weight to this hypothesis? The most reasonable clue comes not from comparative mythology, but from linguistics. As early as 1944, the Assyriologist Benno Landsberger observed something curious in Sumerian vocabulary itself: certain very basic words — the names of the great rivers, *Idiglat* and *Buranun*; the names of the most ancient cities, Eridu, Ur, Larsa, Nippur, Kish; and above all, the names of the foundational crafts — *engar* ("farmer"), *simug* ("smith"), *nangar* ("carpenter"), *damgar* ("merchant") — have no recognizable Sumerian etymology. They do not come from Sumerian. They come from an earlier linguistic layer, spoken by whoever lived in southern Mesopotamia before the Sumerians consolidated as a people.

Landsberger called this layer "Proto-Euphratean." Most scholars today doubt it was a single unified language — it is far more likely there were several — but the central insight still holds: an earlier population lived in southern Mesopotamia, whose legacy survives only in vocabulary, never in its own name, never in its own genealogy. A faceless people in myth, but with a linguistic footprint.

And here lies the piece that opens a suggestive correlation, without closing it: the word that the substratum left for "farmer" — *engar* — is exactly the labor that the newly created humanity performs in *Atrahasis*. The clay-and-blood humans of Geshtu-e will not rule, nor trade, nor serve as priests: they will dig canals and work the land. The full reasoning is modest, and must remain so: a pre-Sumerian substratum exists; the word *engar* belongs to that substratum according to Landsberger; the humans in *Atrahasis* perform precisely that labor; from this follows only a possible conceptual association between "working humanity" and "people prior to the Sumerians" — not proof that the poet of *Atrahasis* consciously had that people in mind while composing.

The parallel is suggestive, not demonstrated: the occupation assigned to the newly created human matches a term many scholars (though not all — Gonzalo Rubio has argued since 1999 against a unified "Proto-Euphratean" substratum, preferring to speak of loans from several distinct languages) consider alien to Sumerian. This does not

prove the myth consciously refers to that earlier population, but it does allow us to consider that the inherited vocabulary and the story of the clay workers belong to the same cultural horizon.

What This Chapter Leaves Open

Honesty compels us to state what this chapter does not resolve. Another passage from the same poem and related texts — the assignment of crafts among the seven birth goddesses, the scene where Ninmah and Enki, drunk, mold bodies with disabilities and assign them courtly destinies — appears to touch on the same theme (creation of humans → distribution of social roles), but belongs to a different logic: that of legitimizing hierarchies within a single ruling elite, not that of narrating the absorption of an external or prior population. That material is set aside here; it belongs to a different kind of analysis — the mythic construction of disability and social status — rather than to the theme of "man made of clay" as origin memory.

What does seem to emerge from this first myth, and forms the starting point for the chapters that follow, is a recurring pattern, sustained above all by what the text itself clearly states — the sacrifice is horizontal, not vertical; the Igigi hand over one of their own, not an enemy — and only tentatively by the linguistic hypothesis just outlined: the material from which the human being is made — clay plus something that already lived, something with a name, an occupation, a prior history — almost never appears as entirely neutral.

Chapter 2 — The Name That Is Inherited: Marduk, Kingu, and the Lullu-Man

The Text

Enuma Elish is later than *Atrahasis*, and it shows. It is no longer the modest account of a labor crisis among lesser gods: it is a coronation poem, written to justify why Babylon rules. It tells how Tiamat, the primordial sea, gathers an army of monsters to avenge the

death of her husband Apsu, and places Kingu at the head of her forces, giving him the Tablet of Destinies and the rank of commander-in-chief.

Marduk — son of Ea, still a lesser god among the great ones — offers to face Tiamat in exchange for being recognized as king by the other gods before battle. He wins. He dismembers Tiamat and fashions the sky and earth from her body. Then, to resolve the same question posed centuries earlier in *Atrahasis* — who will work? — he captures Kingu, accuses him of inciting rebellion, executes him, and from his blood Ea (or Marduk himself, depending on the version) fashions humanity.

Marduk, Assur, and the Interchangeable Victor

Unlike Geshtu-e, Kingu does not die in an assembly of equals. He dies as a defeated enemy, as the leader of a vanquished army, publicly executed by the victor. This is exactly the kind of sacrifice we did not find in *Atrahasis*: the blood of a war rival, not one of one's own. And here the myth scarcely needs interpretation — the names themselves do the work. Marduk became the protagonist of this version because he was elevated to patron god of Babylon — and Mesopotamian tradition confirms this plainly: the copy of the poem found in the city of Assur places the god Assur in Marduk's role. The "hero" changes depending on which city is copying the text. The narrative frame is fixed; the name of the victor is interchangeable. And Marduk's name carries embedded, as thoroughly documented, Mar-tu — the term Mesopotamia used to designate the Amorites — the dynasty that, following the fall of the Third Dynasty of Ur around 2004 BCE, came to rule over southern Mesopotamia and its ancient Sumerian cities. *Enuma Elish* may thus be read, in this respect, as a legitimating poem composed in a context where Babylon, under Amorite dynasties, ruled over territories and traditions inherited from Sumer.

A Hypothesis Concerning Kingu — Presented As Such

And the defeated figure? Here we must be more cautious than phonetic temptation might suggest. Kingu has traditionally been interpreted in Assyriology as a demonized

figure from Tiamat's camp, with an accepted etymology requiring no Sumerian loanword: scholars derive his name from Sumerian roots *kíg* ("laborer") and *kingal* ("leader"), reading it as "*unskilled laborer who rises to rule*" — a reading that in fact fits his role in the plot perfectly, and stands on its own to support the idea that his blood gives rise to a working humanity, without need of additional argument.

This book proposes considering a second possibility, distinct from that accepted etymology: that the choice of Kingu as the enemy whose blood originates humanity may have resonated, for some Babylonian listeners, with the memory of the ancient land of Ki-en-gi — the native name by which the Sumerians themselves called their land. A variant writing of the name in cuneiform, *dqin-gi*, is attested, slightly closer to that reading than the standard form *dqin-gu*. But it must be stated plainly: phonetic resemblance is insufficient to establish a linguistic derivation. One would need to explain the loss of the middle vowel of *Ki-en-gi*, the simplification of that consonant cluster, and why a Babylonian scribe would have reinterpreted a Sumerian place name as a proper divine name. No Assyriologist, as far as can be ascertained, has proposed this reading. It is offered here as a suggestive possibility within a historical context compatible with it — Babylon inheriting and subordinating Sumerian tradition — not as a demonstrated identification.

The Documented Case: Lullubi and the Word Lullû

There is a third case, from a related but distinct textual tradition, that does not depend on any risky phonetic hypothesis — it is the best documented of the three arguments in this chapter, because here the identification need not be proposed: it is already made, embedded within the Akkadian dictionary itself.

The term lullû appears in Akkadian literature to mean *primitive or uncivilized man*, and belongs to the same semantic field as descriptions of newly created humanity in texts such as *Atrahasis* and the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, where it describes Enkidu before his civilization. It is not a proper name: it is the common noun any Akkadian speaker would use for "*untamed man*."

And that word comes from a real people. The Lullubi were Bronze Age tribes settled in the Zagros Mountains, in what is today Iraqi Kurdistan. They were defeated by the great Mesopotamian empires — the most famous episode being the Victory Stele of Naram-Sin, around 2250 BCE, commemorating the victory of the Akkadian king over the mountain Lullubi tribe and their king Satuni — complete with proper names, carved in stone. And by the second millennium BCE, the term "Lullubi" or "Lullu" had already become the generic Babylonian-Assyrian word for "*mountaineer*."

In other words: here we have, without need of any risky hypothesis, the very process proposed tentatively for Kingu — but carried to completion and observable in evidence. The name of a real people, defeated in battle with a king and a commemorative stele, became the common noun for "primitive, newly made, uncivilized man." The victor did not merely seize the defeated people's land: he seized their name, and turned it into a synonym for "the uncivilized other." This may be formulated as a broader comparative principle: in several myths and imperial traditions, the name of the subjugated group survives transformed into a social, ethnic, or anthropological category within the victor's language.

What This Chapter Leaves Open

It is worth noting one semantic nuance that should not be overstated: Akkadian possesses a second distinct word, *lillû*, catalogued in dictionaries as "*fool, simpleton, idiot*" — von Soden translated it directly as German *Tölpel, Idiot, Dummkopf*. It is listed as a separate entry from *lullû* in technical dictionaries (CAD, AHW), with its own Sumerian root (*LIL*). Strictly speaking they are not the same word. But the phonetic resemblance — one vowel difference, identical consonant structure — is undeniable, and in ancient languages that kind of echo almost always blurs together: "*mountaineer/savage/primitive*" easily slides into "*rude/unrefined/foolish*", just as Spanish words like *rústico* or *bárbaro* carry the same weight of contempt today. One need not demonstrate shared origin to observe that both words inhabit the same

neighborhood of contempt toward "the other" — the neighborhood an empire reserves for the people it has just subjugated.

Three Arguments, Three Degrees of Certainty

This chapter brings together three pieces of evidence that do not carry equal weight, and clarity demands we say so upfront. The first — Marduk as legitimization of Amorite rule over Sumer, with Assur replacing him depending on the copying city — is solidly supported by the documented history of the region. The second — Kingu resonating with Ki-en-gi — is an exploratory hypothesis, presented as such, without philological backing elevating it beyond suggestion. The third — Lullubi becoming *lullû* — is the closest of the three to observable evidence: a people with name, king, and defeat stele, whose name is documented transforming into a common term of contempt in the very language of their conqueror.

All three, however, point toward the same principle — and that principle, not any specific identification it illustrates, is what this book advances with greater confidence: the victor changes names depending on who tells the story, but the defeated leave a mark harder to erase, surviving in the very language used to describe newly created humanity.

Chapter 3 — Interlude: What Was Left Out of Sumeria

Before crossing into Egypt, it is worth pausing — not to add a third piece to the pattern established in Chapters 1 and 2, but to explain why certain Sumerian materials that emerged during research were not included. Setting aside what does not meet the bar is as much a part of method as accepting what does.

The Myth of Enki and Ninmah, and Their Seven Goddesses

An older Sumerian version of human creation exists: the poem *Enki and Ninmah*. No god is sacrificed here — Enki, Ninmah, and seven lesser birth goddesses mold the first humans together from clay of the Abzu, no blood involved.

It is tempting to read those seven goddesses as seven distinct peoples — seven miniature Kingu-Kiengi figures — but the myth itself, as currently known, does not confirm this: all seven belong to the same cultic circle, the entourage of Enlil at Nippur, with no documented ethnic or geographic distinction between them. This does not close the door entirely. Further study of each — where each was worshipped separately, whether any had origins distinct from the others before integration into the Nippur circle — might yet uncover something this preliminary review missed. For now, and only for now, it remains outside the book's central argument: not discarded, but not yet known.

Along the way, it is worth recording a curious fact that emerged in research: Zecharia Sitchin popularized the idea of "seven women" lending their wombs to create humanity, and one of them, in his transliteration, appears as something resembling "Susianna." He did not invent it entirely from nothing — Sitchin took the actual name Šuzianna, one of the seven goddesses in the myth, worshipped at Nippur as Enlil's secondary consort. The resemblance to "Susa" (capital of Elam) is entirely coincidental: Šuzianna bears no etymological relation to Elam. This is noted here precisely to make clear: this was not overlooked, it was investigated and discarded on reasonable grounds.

The Temptation of Ninti-Elam

A second thread opened and closed during research was the possible reading of Ninti — the goddess "Lady of the Rib," created in the myth of Enki and Ninhursag to heal Enki's rib, whose name plays on the Sumerian double meaning of *ti* as both "rib" and "life" — as a form of *Nim-ti*, "High Land" (Elam, whose native Sumerian name *NIM.MA.KI* means exactly that — "High Land," the same semantic field as the Elamite name *Atam-ti*).

The problem is that NIN and NIM are two distinct cuneiform signs, not two readings of the same sign — unlike Kingu-Ki-en-gi, where no sign change is required at all.

Ninti/Nimti belongs, within this book's evidence framework, to a weaker category: a defensible phonetic resemblance hypothesis (nasal assimilation $n \rightarrow m$ is a real linguistic phenomenon), but not a reading of the sign itself. Furthermore, the myth of Enki and Ninhursag recounts no conflict or exchange between peoples that might anchor the identification in something more than sound-alike resemblance. By deliberate decision, this line was not developed as a full chapter: the piece is noted here as an open hypothesis for anyone who wishes to pursue it, not as a demonstrated argument of the book.

Why This Is Recorded

Chapters 1 and 2 hold together because in both cases there is something more than phonetic resemblance: a narrative context of subjugation (labor crisis resolved with foreign blood; war with victor and vanquished), backed by verifiable historical identification (the pre-Sumerian substratum in one case; Amorite conquest of Sumeria and Naram-Sin's Victory Stele in the other). The material in this chapter does not yet reach that threshold — neither in narrative context with the seven goddesses, nor in sign reading with Ninti-Nimti — and therefore no firm argument is built upon it here. But "not yet" is not "never": this record is left here, not as closed material, but as a map of what was investigated, what fell short, and what might well qualify with further work.

Chapter 4 — The Potter's Wheel of the Nile: Khnum of Elephantine

The Text

At Egypt's southernmost edge, where the Nile enters the country through the First Cataract, stands Elephantine — and here, from at least the Old Kingdom onward, was worshipped Khnum, the ram-headed god. His temple controlled mythologically

something very concrete: the annual flood, the inundation that brought fertile silt upon which all Egyptian agriculture depended.

Khnum does not create humanity all at once, as Enki or Marduk did. He creates them one by one, each person separately, upon his own potter's wheel — the very tool any Egyptian potter used to shape a vessel. He takes clay from the Nile itself, fashions it into human form upon the wheel, and breathes into each figure the *ka*, the life force that animates it. He was called, in some texts, "*the one who shapes upon the wheel*," and also "*father of fathers, mother of mothers*" — a god who creates without need of a partner, using only hands and the turning wheel.

Individual, Not Mass-Produced

Something distinguishes Khnum immediately from everything seen in Mesopotamia. In *Atrahasis* and *Enuma Elish*, humanity is created all at once, in a single foundational act, from a single sacrificed body shared among all. With Khnum it is otherwise: each person has their own moment upon the wheel. The text does not describe an entire people shaped at once from the clay of a sacrificed god — it describes a continuous, repeated, craft process, one by one, generation after generation.

This carries a direct consequence for the book's purpose: if the pattern traced in Mesopotamia was "*distinct material = distinct or subjugated people*," the myth of Khnum offers no such hook. No war, no conquered people, no rival god's blood mixed into the clay. There is instead something closer to what will later be found in Nubia and among the Shilluk: the idea that each person, not each people, is made separately — a detail worth keeping in mind, because in those later chapters it will be *differences in processing time or clay color* that explain differences between peoples.

What Khnum Does Contribute to the Book's Argument

Where Khnum fits powerfully is on the book's second axis — not conquest, but technology. The Egyptian verb used for what Khnum does is literally the vocabulary of

the potter's trade. His cult was intertwined with symbolic control of the Nile flood — the very foundation of Egyptian agriculture. The god who fashions humans from clay is, plainly, the god who controls the fertile mud upon which the civilization worshipping him depends. No full chapter of Neolithic archaeology is needed to see this: the myth itself makes explicit the equation clay–agriculture–life that in Mesopotamia had to be reconstructed through the linguistics of the pre-Sumerian substratum.

A Note Concerning the Pharaoh

One particular tradition about Khnum deserves mention, though it does not alter the central argument: he was believed to play a special role in the birth of the pharaoh himself, personally fashioning the future king and his *ka* within the queen's womb. This is not a hierarchy of materials — there is no "royal clay" distinct from common clay, as there will be in China between Nüwa's handiwork and the cord's splatter. It is rather special divine attention bestowed upon the monarchy, applied atop the same egalitarian craft method Khnum uses for everyone. Egypt, as will be seen in the next chapter, chose to stratify at a different point in the life cycle — not at birth, but in access to immortality after death — and that story belongs to Ptah, not Khnum.

Chapter 5 — The Heart That Names: Ptah of Memphis

The Text

The Shabaka Stone, inscribed around 716–702 BCE by order of the Nubian king Shabaka, preserves a cosmogonical account unlike any seen so far. Unlike other Egyptian creation accounts — where creation proceeds through physiological acts (Atum spits or vomits forth his children; beings emerge from Ra's semen) — here the god Ptah generates the cosmos through the thought of his heart and the word of his tongue. Ptah conceives in his heart the idea of Atum and all other gods, and by naming them with his tongue, calls them into existence. Egyptologists do not avoid the comparison: it is difficult not to think of the *"In the beginning was the Word"* from the Gospel of John.

This cosmogony is not innocent. It is religious propaganda from Memphis, composed by its priesthood to absorb and subordinate rival cosmogonies from Heliopolis (where the creator is Atum) and Hermopolis (where creation emerges from the primordial waters of Nun) into a single narrative — presenting those older gods as if they were, in reality, ideas conceived in Ptah's heart before they ever existed on their own.

The Same God, Two Trades

Ptah possesses, however, a second face seldom told alongside the first. He is also, and above all, the patron god of craftsmen, with special affiliation to stone and clay arts. This craft identity does not remain confined to cosmic creation: it extends into death and rebirth, because as master craftsman, Ptah came to be understood as the creator of new bodies the deceased would inhabit in the afterlife. The god who thinks the universe in his heart is the same god who, with his hands, carves stone or molds the clay bodies people will need after death.

In some local traditions, this craft aspect of Ptah merges directly with Khnum: it is said that together they created the universe, under the direction of Thoth, beginning from a primordial egg — and that Khnum, together with Ptah, was responsible for shaping human beings upon the potter's wheel. Memphis competes not merely for prestige of having *thought* the cosmos; through this same figure, it also claims prestige of having *made* it with hands.

Immortality Must Be Paid For

Egypt did not stratify its human creation myth by using different materials, as other peoples did. It stratified at a different moment in the life cycle: access to divinity after death — and that access passed through the hands, once again, of the craft tradition Ptah represents.

The Pyramid Texts, from around 2400 BCE, were exclusively for the pharaoh: their sole purpose was to assist him in taking his place among the gods beside his divine father Ra. Over time, in what Egyptologists call the "democratization of the royal afterlife," these texts ceased to be the privilege of kings and passed to the nobility, becoming the Coffin Texts. By the New Kingdom, the Book of the Dead circulated among all social classes — but with one condition: immortality was reserved for those who could recite its formulas and afford the embalming and burial rituals.

It is the same logic that separated, in Sumer and in China, those molded with care from those splashed hurriedly — except here the dividing line is drawn not at birth, but at death. The new body Ptah promises to carve in the afterlife is not free for anyone; it is literally a craft service that must be paid for.

Chapter 6 — The Cord and the Hand: Nüwa

The Text

The source is precise, with name, date, and author: the *Fengsu Tongyi* ("Comprehensive Meaning of Customs"), written by the scholar Ying Shao around 195 CE, during the Han Dynasty. It is not religious scripture nor a cosmic origin myth narrated by priests — it is a treatise on the customs of his time, which already tells us something: when Ying Shao recorded this story, he did not do so to explain the universe, but to explain why the society before him was organized as it was.

He relates that Nüwa kneaded yellow earth and fashioned human beings. But working one by one was too slow. So she dipped a cord into the mud, swung it, and the drops that splashed also became people.

Method as Destiny

The text does not linger over the technical anecdote. It proceeds directly to the social consequence, stated plainly: she used fine yellow clay for nobles and the wealthy; cord-flung mud for commoners and the poor. The method of manufacture — careful

handiwork versus mass splatter — is not a mere process detail. It is literally the mechanism that divides humanity into those who rule and those who do not.

No additional interpretation is needed to reach this reading, because the text itself says it explicitly, in the very sentence describing the method. Ying Shao is not telling a story about the origin of humanity in general; he is telling a story about why, in Han Dynasty China of the 2nd century CE, there are nobles and commoners. And the answer he gives is: because they were made that way, from the beginning of the world — some by hand, others flung in haste.

Shared and Distinctive Features

In *Atrahasis*, *Enuma Elish*, and the Lullû story, social distinction was explained through a conquered people — an enemy defeated in war or absorbed through conquest. With Nüwa, there is no war, no rival people, no sacrificed god's blood. There is instead one creator goddess and one material — always the same yellow earth. What changes is not where the clay comes from, but how it is worked. This is a myth about production process, not ethnic origin: inequality does not arise because one people conquered another, but because creation itself — from the goddess's workshop — operates at two distinct speeds: one slow and artisanal, reserved for the few; the other mass-produced and careless, for everyone else.

In this sense it is the myth that most literally turns the act of creation into a scene of labor — not war, not religious sacrifice, but assembly-line production alongside individual craftsmanship, with identical material and identical creator, more than eighteen centuries ago.

Chapter 7 — Clay That Melts Away: The Popol Vuh

The Text

The Popol Vuh, sacred book of the K'iche' Maya, recounts the creation of humanity as a series of successive attempts, not a single perfect act. The creator gods — Tepeu, Gucumatz, Huracán — need beings capable of naming them, honoring them, and counting time. To achieve this, they try, fail, and try again.

The first attempt is clay. The gods mold a human figure from wet earth. It does not work: the figure dissolves in rain, cannot stand upright, speaks without sense, and its legs buckle beneath its own weight. The gods dissolve it and begin anew. The second attempt is wood — it also fails: the wooden people have no memory, no heart, do not remember their creators, and are eventually destroyed by their own tools and domestic animals turning against them. Only the third attempt, made from corn dough, produces beings capable of speaking, thinking, and honoring those who made them.

A Failure That Is No Accident

Of all myths gathered in this book, the Popol Vuh is the only one in which clay explicitly fails. In Mesopotamia, Egypt, and China, clay works — though with varying social outcomes. Here it does not: rain itself dissolves what the gods have just molded. The detail is far from trivial. A clay figure dissolving in water is, with near technical precision, the description of unfired or low-fired pottery. Raw clay softens with moisture; fired clay does not. Read this way, the myth recounts not merely material preference — clay vs. wood vs. corn — but within clay itself: the failure of an immature technology, clay not yet mastered to resist rain, a stage left behind and superseded, not even needing explicit mention in the later attempts.

Food, Not Earth

Another feature separates the Popol Vuh from all accounts seen so far: the material that finally succeeds is not a mineral, nor a symbolic substitute for a sacrificed god's body. It is corn — the very food upon which Maya civilization depended for survival. Successful humanity is made not from the ground they walk upon, but from the harvest that feeds them. The link between creation material and daily subsistence — which in other myths

had to be reconstructed through archaeology or linguistics — is stated here plainly by the narrative itself: we are literally what we eat, and the gods took two failed attempts to realize that this, not earth or wood, was the right material.

Chapter 8 — The Spider Woman Who Sings: Kokyangwuti

The Text

In Hopi cosmology, the present world is not the first. Before this — the Fourth World — there were others, each destroyed in turn: by fire, by ice, by flood. Each time a world collapses, a group survives and emerges into the next, guided by Kokyangwuti, the Spider Grandmother, also called Spider Woman.

She was created by Sótuknang in the First World to be his helper in giving life.

Following his instructions, Kokyangwuti took earth and mixed it with *túchvala* — liquid from her own mouth — and molded the first creatures. In one version of the story, she used earth of four distinct colors — yellow, red, white, and black — mixed with her saliva. Singing the Song of Creation, she first made four men, then taking her own form as model, four women.

At first these beings could not speak. They had a soft spot on the forehead through which they could hear the Creator's voice, but no way to reply. Kokyangwuti then called upon Sótuknang, who gave them four distinct languages.

Four Colors, Four Peoples

Unlike Khnum, who molded each person individually from the same clay, and unlike Nüwa, where material stays identical and what changes is technique — here the very color of the earth is the variable distinguishing one human group from another from the first moment of creation. No war, no sacrifice, no subsequent conquest is needed for distinct peoples to exist: difference is built into the material itself, in four kinds of earth that were already different before anyone touched them.

Furthermore, the myth does not separate the creation of humanity from the teaching of the crafts that sustain it: Kokyangwuti taught people how to plant, weave, and make pottery. Clay does not merely make people — immediately afterward, those same people learn to work clay themselves, closing a circle that in other traditions remains split across separate myths: here creation and livelihood share the same scene, told in the same voice.

A World That Ends — and Begins Again

The cycle of Four Worlds adds something no other account in this book offers with such clarity: destruction is not a single event, but a repeating pattern. Each world collapses differently, and each time the same guide — Kokyangwuti — leads survivors into the next. It is not one flood followed by one final humanity: it is a sequence of destructions, each distinct from the last, with one figure crossing through them all — who, at the very beginning, also molded the first people from earth of four colors.

Chapter 9 — Clay Color and Kiln Time: Shilluk and Nubia

Juok and the Clay of Each Region

Among the Shilluk, a people dwelling along the Nile in present-day South Sudan, the creator god Juok traveled the whole world making humanity. And in each place he used the material he found beneath his feet: white earth in the north, from which he made white people; reddish Nile clay in Egypt, from which he made brown-skinned people; and the rich black soil of the Nile banks in Shilluk land, from which he made black people. Only after shaping them did he give them legs to walk and work, and organs enabling them to reproduce without aid.

This account was recorded independently by two distinct, nearly contemporary observers: the German linguist Diedrich Westermann, who conducted fieldwork among the Shilluk around 1910, and the Austrian missionary Wilhelm Hofmayr, who lived among them from 1906 to 1916. That two persons with different backgrounds and

purposes — one a scholar, one a religious missionary — collected the same tradition separately gives it uncommon corroboration among the myths gathered here.

No hidden key or phonetic game is needed to read the message: the myth says plainly, without allegory, that different skin colors come from different earth taken from different regions by the same god on the same journey. Of all worldwide accounts collected in this book, this is the clearest, least ambiguous instance of an equation other myths leave only implied: distinct material = distinct people.

Nubia: The Kiln That Did Not Yet Know Timing

North of the Shilluk, in the region the Bible calls Cush, another account was recorded reaching the same conclusion by a different route. A divinity molded a human figure from clay and placed it in the kiln to fire. Since no human had yet been created, the god did not know how long to leave it inside: it was left too long, and came out burnt, with black skin — placed in the lands of the First Nile Cataracts. Wishing to correct the mistake, the god fired a second one for less time: it came out very pale-skinned, placed in the north, beyond the Nile Delta.

This myth does not speak of different earth taken from different places, as the Shilluk account does. It speaks of one single process — firing — applied with differing outcome through sheer inexperience. Difference between peoples lies not in starting material, but in imperfect mastery of a technology the Creator himself was still learning on the fly.

Two Myths, One Shared Gesture

Together these two accounts — one centered on raw material, the other on firing process — complete, among African peoples, exactly the two axes running through this entire book: what is chosen to make the human being, and how that material is worked once chosen. No other pair of myths lays those two axes so clearly separated, yet so clearly united by one purpose: to explain, without ambiguity or hidden allegory, why all people are not alike.

Chapter 10 — The Drunken Potter: Obatala

The Text

Before dry land existed, there was only water and sky. Olodumare, the supreme being, entrusted Obatala with the task of creating the firm ground upon which life could stand, and gave him what was needed: a golden chain, a seashell filled with sand, a white hen, and a palm seed. Obatala descended the chain into the primordial waters, poured out the sand from the shell, and released the hen — who scattered the sand in all directions with her feet. Dry land emerged, and upon it was founded Ile-Ife, the first city, the navel of the world according to Yoruba tradition.

With land established, Olodumare entrusted Obatala with a second task: to mold human bodies from the clay of this newly created earth. And here the narrative turns in a direction found nowhere else in this book: while working, Obatala drank palm wine, and intoxication made his hands unsteady. Some of the figures he molded in that state emerged misshapen or bearing physical imperfections.

A Creator Who Errs — Not Material That Fails

In the Popol Vuh, it was the clay itself that failed, unable to withstand rain. Here the clay has no defect whatsoever — the error lies entirely with the Creator, and his condition while working. This is a significant variation on the same theme: human imperfection is explained not by hierarchy of materials, nor by earth color, but by accident — by the state of the potter whose hands were upon the clay that day.

Some versions add a second twist: while Obatala slept off his intoxication, his brother Oduduwa took charge, completed the work, and eventually became the first king of Ile-Ife. A god who falls asleep at the decisive moment, and a rival who seizes that absence to found political power upon the very city the first had created.

Clay, Hen, and Sand: Foundation Before Creation

It is worth noting that this myth, unlike almost all others in the book, does not begin with the human being — it begins with territory. Before molding a single body, Obatala must fashion the very ground upon which that body will stand, with a hen scattering sand over the waters. The creation of the clay human is not the first act: it is the second, and depends entirely upon the first — the founding of a firm place, a city — having already been accomplished. The human does not arrive into a ready-made world; arrives into a specific city founded only moments before, and made by the same hands that will later shape him.

Chapter 11 — The Material That Sustains: Pottery, Sedentism, and Corn

A Second Reading of the Same Motif

So far, the clay in these myths has been read chiefly as identity marker: which people, which class, which hierarchy is written into the material one is made from. But a second, more technical reading is possible — not competing with the first, but completing it: clay does not only tell you who you are; it tells you upon what material foundation the civilization telling the story depends.

The standard reference entry already notes this: numerous ancient religions and mythologies explain human birth through gods acting as potters — and cuneiform tablets from the late 4th millennium BCE are the oldest known documents narrating human creation through modeling. It is no coincidence that the trade chosen to fashion humanity is, time and again, the very trade upon which storing grain, carrying water, and cooking food depend — the trade, in short, that enables people to cease wandering after food and begin settling in one place.

What Archaeology Confirms — and Qualifies

The actual sequence, however, is slower and less orderly than myth suggests. In the Near East, sedentism, agriculture, and animal husbandry were already underway from the early Neolithic — centuries of permanent villages without pottery, relying instead on basketry, leather, and stone (the so-called Pre-Pottery Neolithic). Pottery did not invent settled life: it arrived later, and what it did was consolidate and scale it. It permitted storage of grain surpluses and water at a scale basketry could not support; transformed cooking; enabled trade in commodities.

And this sequence — settlement first, pottery later as reinforcing technology — is not universal. In the Far East, the oldest known pottery (China, ~18,000 years ago; Japan, ~16,700 years ago) precedes Near Eastern pottery by thousands of years, and appears among hunter-gatherers still without agriculture or permanent villages. Pottery in those contexts was independent of sedentism entirely: an innovation invented separately in multiple regions, not a single technological package diffusing from one origin.

The correct reading of the myth, then, is not *"clay invented civilization everywhere equally"* — but something more precise: in the particular Mesopotamian region that produced these myths, mastery of clay — for vessels and symbolically for human form — coincides with the moment that society consolidated settled life. Myth does not describe a universal law of human technology; it describes, with reasonable fidelity, the lived experience of the people who told it.

Maya Corn: The Same Argument, Different Material

Read through this same lens, the Popol Vuh does not break the pattern — it confirms it from the opposite direction. If clay represents, in Mesopotamia, the technology upon which subsistence depends, the material that finally triumphs in the Maya account — corn — is exactly the same thing, translated to the crop upon which Mesoamerica depended.

And archaeology once again provides a timeline slower than myth, yet hauntingly parallel. Corn was domesticated from teosinte some 9,000 years ago in the Balsas River

valley, present-day Guerrero — a date, in fact, remarkably close to that of the earliest Near Eastern pottery. But domestication did not instantly make it staple food: evidence suggests corn became a significant dietary component only between 4,700 and 4,000 years ago, becoming dietary staple thereafter — meaning several thousand years elapsed between first domestication and the moment corn truly sustained the population. Before that time, it has been proposed its earliest use may have been sweet juice from the stalk, fermented into an alcoholic beverage — ears being too small at that time to carry meaningful dietary weight.

Read alongside the myth, the parallel is difficult to ignore: the Popol Vuh recounts two failed attempts before reaching the right material — and real agricultural history took millennia to move from botanical curiosity to sustaining civilization. Myth compresses into three narrative attempts what reality took thousands of years to resolve — but the order of the story: failure after failure until finding the material that truly feeds, is identical in both.

Chapter 12 — The Potter Without a Name: Genesis 2:4–7

The Text — and Only the Text

This chapter deliberately restricts itself to four verses: Genesis 2:4–7. It excludes the tree, the serpent, the garden setting — those belong to a different narrative strand with its own logic, treated separately. What remains, isolated thus, is the briefest, most ancient scene in the entire corpus assembled in this book:

Then the Lord God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul.

Four elements, no more: a verb, a material, a gesture, and a result.

The Verb Is Not Neutral

The Hebrew verb translated "*formed*" is *yatsar* — and it is not a generic verb for "made" or "created." It is, specifically, the technical verb of the potter's trade. From the same root comes *yotser*, "potter" — and this same verb *yatsar* is used centuries later by the prophet Jeremiah to describe the potter working clay upon the wheel. The text itself leaves no ambiguity: this is not birth, not emanation, not a word spoken and done — it is lexically the same gesture of hands upon clay seen in Khnum turning his wheel, Ptah fashioning bodies, and Spider Woman singing over the clay as she shapes it.

The Material: Dust, Not Simply Earth

The material too is not generic. The text says 'aphar, "dust," taken from ha-'adamah, "the ground" — the very root from which, two verses earlier, the name 'adam (man) derives. A wordplay explicit in Hebrew, no ancient reader could miss: man ('*adam*) is made from the ground ('*adamah*), and his name says so before the story is half told. No other myth in this book constructs that double meaning within the very name of the first being with such economy — two words, one shared root, destiny written already in the sound.

The Gesture That Gives Life

What distinguishes this clay figure from mere statue is breath: God breathes directly into his nostrils, and dust becomes "*a living being*" — *nefesh chayah*, the same expression Genesis uses for animals. No sacrificed god's blood as in *Atrahasis* or *Enuma Elish*; no splattering cord as with Nüwa; no song as with Spider Woman. Only breath, direct, mouth-to-nostril, nothing in between. Of all myths in this book, this one reduces the animating gesture to its absolute minimum: no alien blood, no chanted words — only the breath of the Creator passing directly into the creature's body.

A Text That Already Knew Comparison

It is worth closing by noting what these verses do not need explained: a god fashioning with hands from the very ground people walk upon, then breathing life into the figure — this idea was not invented here. It is the same scene, told with the most economical vocabulary of the entire corpus, already recounted — with more ceremony, more blood, more attendant gods — by Mesopotamia, Egypt, China, and many others before and alongside these four verses being written down.

Chapter 13 — Man Made of 'Aphar

One Root, Three Languages

Genesis 2:7 states man was formed from 'aphar, "dust." This word is not unique to Hebrew. It is a shared Semitic root: Phoenician *'afar* carries identical meaning "dust, earth"; Arabic independently confirms the same root: *'afara* ("to be dusty") from *'afar*, "dust, earth." Three distinct Semitic languages — Hebrew, Phoenician, Arabic — converge on identical consonant root and meaning. Not an isolated coincidence: common vocabulary across an entire language family. This is the most secure piece of evidence in this chapter, and carries the greatest weight.

The Sahara That Dried Up

For much of the early and middle Holocene, the Sahara was not the desert it is today. The so-called African Humid Period covered the region with lakes, grasslands, and rivers. Its end was not sudden: a slow process spanning more than three thousand years, with a turning point roughly 6,000 years ago. As desertification advanced, entire populations were forced to migrate in search of habitable land — and one documented route led precisely through the corridor connecting northeast Africa to the Levant, across Sinai and Palestine, into Asia.

This same region and timeframe are precisely what historical linguistics identifies as the likely homeland of the Afroasiatic language family — to which Hebrew, Phoenician, Arabic, Ancient Egyptian, and Berber belong, among others. The Assyriologist Igor

Diakonoff placed the origin of this family in the Sahara itself, with subsequent migrations beginning roughly 5000 BCE, including the exit from Africa of speakers who would become the Semitic languages. Other linguists such as Christopher Ehret place that same origin in the central Sahara during the African Humid Period. This is not the only school — some scholars prefer placing Afroasiatic origins directly in the Levant, reversing migration direction — but the Saharan hypothesis has serious, mainstream advocates, not merely marginal ones.

And the dates align with striking precision: Proto-Semitic, the reconstructed ancestor of Hebrew, Phoenician, and Arabic, is dated roughly 4500–3900 BCE — exactly the closing centuries of the Saharan drying phase, and exactly when those same migration routes toward the Levant were already in use.

Formed — Then Placed

Genesis 2:7 does not end with formation. The very next verse relocates him: *"and he placed him in the Garden of Eden."* Two verbs, two movements: formed from material, then transplanted elsewhere. Read alongside the foregoing, the very order of the narrative reproduces in two verbs what archaeology and linguistics document separately: origin in the land of dust, followed by migration toward the Fertile Crescent along the same corridor others had traveled before.

A Note: Possible Relation to the Name "Africa"

One additional, more contested hypothesis deserves separate mention — precisely because it is far less secure than the foregoing evidence, and the chapter's argument does not depend upon it. One of the two principal etymologies proposed for the name "Africa" derives it from Phoenician *'afar*, "dust" or "earth." The competing etymology, widely favored in modern linguistics, derives it from Berber *ifri*, "cave." Neither of them is closed, and there's no way to settle that argument here.

If the Phoenician hypothesis were correct, the name "Africa" would share the same Semitic root as the dust from which Adam was made — and the phrase would carry a striking symmetry between the name of a continent and the material from which the first man was formed. But this remains a conditional possibility, not a conclusion: the chapter does not require this etymology to be true in order to stand, and it is set apart deliberately, so that it does not bear more weight than it can carry.

Chapter 14 — The Adam Who Wandered the Mountains: Edom Before There Was a Kingdom

A God Who Came from the South

The most ancient poetic layers of the Hebrew Bible do not place Yahweh's origin in Canaan. They place it in the mountains, to the south:

"Yahweh came from Seír, shone forth to them from Mount Parán" — Deuteronomy 33:2

"Yahweh, when you marched out of Seír, when you set forth from the fields of Edom..." — Judges 5:4

"God came from Teman..." — Habakkuk 3 ☺

"Who is this coming from Edom, from Bozrah...?" — Isaiah 63:1

Seír, Edom, Teman, Parán — all names for the same mountainous territory south and east of the Dead Sea. This reading, known among scholars as the Kenite Hypothesis, is not marginal: it was developed by Frank Moore Cross and is upheld by scholars including Joseph Blenkinsopp. The biblical text itself, in its oldest layers, preserves the memory of a god who was not born in Canaan — he arrived from the southern mountains.

And there is testimony older than any biblical manuscript confirming that this memory is not a late invention: the topographical lists from the temple of Soleb, inscribed by order of Amenhotep III around the 15th century BCE, mention "the land of the Shasu of Yhw" — the oldest known extra-biblical testimony to the divine name. The Shasu were nomadic groups whom the Egyptians themselves documented roaming that same

mountainous region for centuries: Ramses II boasted of raiding the land of the Shasu and capturing Mount Seír; a papyrus from the time of Merenptah, around 1206 BCE, records Shasu clans from Edom crossing into Egyptian territory in search of pasture for their flocks.

Villages — Not a Kingdom

Throughout this entire period — from the 15th century BCE well into the first millennium BCE — Edom was not a kingdom. Excavations in the region (Busayra, Khirbat en-Nahas, Tell el-Kheleifeh) place the formation of Edom as a centralized state with capital, court, and administrative apparatus toward the late 8th century BCE, formed under stimulus or pressure from the Assyrian Empire itself. Before that, what existed were small villages and pastoral camps in the mountains — exactly the human landscape the Egyptian lists had already described a thousand years earlier: Shasu, Midianites, people living by livestock, moving with the seasons, without king, without capital, worshipping a god who traveled with them wherever they camped.

This is the Adam of this book. Not the Adam of a named garden with fixed geography — but the generic Man of the villages in the mountains of Seír, centuries before any kingdom existed that would bear the name Edom. The same Adam whose name shares a root with *adamah* (the land), and with Edom itself — "Red," after the reddish soil of those very mountains.

The Mixture That Founded a Kingdom

From those mountains, some clans migrated and mingled — with Midianites, with other desert groups, and finally with the established Canaanite population further north. From that mixture Judah emerged. It is the same pattern, allowing for differences in scale, already seen in Mesopotamia: a nomadic group from the highlands or desert descends upon an already settled population, merges with them, and eventually gives the emerging kingdom its own god, its own founding name, its own identity — just as the Amorites, desert nomads from the Syrian steppe, descended upon the ancient

Sumerian cities and founded Babylon with Marduk, a god from outside, at the head of the local pantheon.

And as with every foundation of this kind, the mixture does not erase the boundary — it reinforces it toward those who stayed behind. Once consolidated, the kingdoms of Israel and Judah treated Edom not as a close relative to whom they owed a portion of their own identity — but as a rival neighbor, sometimes an enemy, against whom the southern border must be defended. The very people from whom the original Adam came became, to their own settled descendants, "the other." The same paradox encountered once again with Marduk and Kingu: the victor inherits the name and lineage of the vanquished, then builds his political identity by denying that kinship.

Exile — and the Encounter with Atam-ti

Centuries later, when Judah fell and its elite were deported to Babylon, that same community in exile gained direct access to Mesopotamian cuneiform literature. The resemblances between Genesis 1–11 and *Atrahasis*, *Enuma Elish*, and the *Epic of Gilgamesh* — documented by biblical criticism for more than a century — are explained precisely by this contact. But the contact was not limited to Babylon: archival records document Jews living and leaving cuneiform records in Susa, capital of Elam itself, during the first decades of the exile. Ration lists from the palace of Nebuchadnezzar record Elamite guards and Jewish courtiers serving together in the same administrative space.

It was in that contact — not before — that Jewish scribes in exile learned the name the Elamites themselves gave their land: Atam-ti, "High Land." A name that, to ears already carrying the tradition of an Adam from Edom, from the mountains, must have sounded like something more than mere coincidence. There, in exile — with Mesopotamian creation material and the Elamite name already available — the ancient memory of an Adam from the southern mountains — Edomite, Shasu, worshiper of Yahweh before Yahweh ever arrived in Israel — merged with the Mesopotamian narrative of clay-made

man and the name of the Elamite highland, to produce the composite text we read today as Genesis 2.

What reaches us is not a single story. It is at least five stories woven together: the memory of a god and a people from the mountains of Seír; the Mesopotamian tradition of man molded from clay; the name of a highland land; the lived, documented experience of dwelling in exile beside that land; and stitched over all of it — the need of a people who had lost everything, to explain once more, to themselves: where they came from.

Epilogue

Fourteen chapters, fourteen distinct ways of answering the same question — and yet one single gesture repeats itself from one end of the book to the other: someone, somewhere, looks at the clay in their hands and decides that here, and nowhere else, the story of humanity begins.

In Mesopotamia, that gesture carries the blood of another and the weight of forced labor — a god sacrificed by his own; an enemy defeated in war; a vanquished people whose name survives transformed into the word for "the uncivilized other."

In Egypt, that same gesture is shared between a potter's wheel fashioning each person one by one, and a heart that conceives the entire cosmos before naming it — and hierarchy, when it comes, hides not in the material but in who can afford passage to the afterlife.

In China, clay is divided between careful hands and a flicked cord — and that single difference in method suffices to separate nobles from commoners.

In Mesoamerica, clay fails outright — and it takes corn, not earth, not wood, to finally make humanity work.

In North America, the very color of the clay is already skin color from the moment the Creator sings it into being.

In Africa, two neighboring peoples reach the same truth by separate roads: one looking at the earth they stood upon, the other counting the hours the clay spent in the fire. And at the far end of the journey, in the Levant, that same gesture is told with the utmost economy of the entire corpus: one verb for potter, one handful of dust, one breath blown inward. Four words that, read alongside everything that came before, cease to sound like an isolated origin story — and begin to sound like the briefest, most concise version of a story that had already been told, with more ceremony and more gods, many times before.

This book does not claim to have proven that all these accounts share a single origin, nor that its boldest identifications — Kingu as memory of Sumer, Geshtu-e as faceless people, Adam of the red earth — are established facts. It claims, more modestly, to have shown that the question deserves to be asked with care: that the material a people says they were made from is almost never an innocent choice — and that paying attention to that material — where it came from, how it was worked, what was mixed into it — remains a legitimate way of listening to what an ancient civilization chose to tell about itself. Even when it told that story in code. Even when no one remains who can confirm whether we read the code aright.

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